

Does Hall Really Challenge the DAR?

Reconstructing the Historical and Genetic Reality of Asa Hall (1758–1841)

2026 Revision and Corroboration of the 2000 Hall Lineage Study

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Abstract

For decades, institutional genealogical records incorrectly linked the pioneer Asa Hall of Montgomery County, Virginia, to an aristocratic colonial lineage out of Wallingford, Connecticut. That connection was based on the volatile methodology of surname-matching across distinct regional archives, amplified by the 1970 DAR publication *A Slice of History: A Story of a Hall Family of America*.

This ledger revisits and corrects the speculative Connecticut hypotheses advanced in Hall (2000), deferring throughout to the more rigorous Rhode Island synthesis by Wanda Ware DeGidio. It brings together four converging lines of evidence:

1. **Scholarly lineage research** — DeGidio's reconstruction of the Rhode Island-to-New York Hall line.
2. **Primary land records** — Virginia state land grants demonstrating independent frontier land tenure.
3. **Probate evidence** — the 1841 estate appraisal and dower allotment, which provide the material reality of Asa Hall's life.
4. **Genetic genealogy** — Y-DNA data that are *consistent with* DeGidio's framework and inconsistent with the Connecticut hypothesis, but are treated as supportive rather than conclusive.

The result is a corrected, evidence-based biography of a Revolutionary War veteran and Appalachian pioneer whose legacy was clouded by earlier long-shot theories and institutional name-matching.

Preface: From the 2000 Foundation to a Corrected Narrative

The original Hall lineage study completed in 2000 performed valuable service by questioning the 1970 DAR narrative and by assembling the early Virginia land records and probate materials that anchor this report. It also, however, advanced long-shot theories—most notably a tentative Wallingford, Connecticut, ancestry—that are not supported by the documentary or genetic evidence now available.

This 2026 revision rejects those speculative hypotheses and defers instead to Wanda Ware DeGidio's detailed reconstruction of the Rhode Island Hall line. Where the 2000 manuscript could only raise possibilities, DeGidio's work provides the documented migration path from Rhode Island through New York to the Virginia frontier. DNA and the Virginia primary records are presented here as corroborating, not supplanting, her lineage research.

Section I: Y-DNA as a Check, Not a Proof

The 2000 manuscript entertained a possible Connecticut origin for the Montgomery County Halls, and the 1970 DAR publication asserted one. Neither was grounded in the careful, locality-by-locality documentation that DeGidio later supplied. Genetic testing now offers a useful check on those long-shot theories without replacing the need for paper-trail research.

Paternal lineages from the Connecticut-based Hall families consistently exhibit the **R-M269 haplogroup**, common among many New England settlers. Direct, documented male-line descendants of the Southwest Virginia Hall family carry a different classification within **Haplogroup G-M201** (the G2a subgroup). This mismatch means that the Southwest Virginia Halls do not share a recent paternal ancestor with the Connecticut Hall families that were proposed as kin.

On its own, a haplogroup does not name an ancestor or prove a specific lineage. It can, however, rule out a recent shared paternal line. Because the proposed Connecticut connection rests on name-matching rather than continuous documentation, the Y-DNA finding supports the decision to set that long-shot theory aside and follow DeGidio's documented Rhode Island-to-New York migration path.

Conclusion: The genetic profile is incompatible with a recent paternal link to the Connecticut Hall families. It is consistent with the separate Rhode Island branch traced by DeGidio, and it underscores why the Connecticut hypothesis should no longer be pursued.

Section II: The Rhode Island to New York Migration — The DeGidio Synthesis

With the Connecticut hypothesis rejected as a long-shot unsupported by the sources, the working account of the Hall line follows the migration framework established by **Wanda Ware DeGidio**. Her research provides the continuous, locality-based documentation that the 2000 study lacked. The Y-DNA profile is treated here as a supporting clue, not as the foundation of the argument.

The true paternal lineage develops across seven generations:

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John Hall I (Rhode Island)
  → Henry Hall II
    → James Hall
      → Joseph Hall
        → Benajah Hall
          → Asa Hall / Jesse Hall (Montgomery County, VA)
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According to DeGidio's reconstruction, the family's earliest American roots are in Rhode Island. Mid-eighteenth-century land movements then carried Benajah Hall's family northward and westward into

the colonial borders of New York. This New York residency supplies the context for Asa Hall's Revolutionary War service in New York regiments and explains why institutional name indexes mistakenly associated him with Connecticut and Rhode Island soldiers of the same name.

As documented in his congressional pension file granted on June 17, 1833, Asa Hall enlisted in New York. His military records detail the following service:

- **March 1776 – December 1776:** Served as a private in the New York Regiment under Captain Nathan Pierce, fighting at the Battle of Long Island and the Battle of White Plains.
- **July 1, 1777 – December 1777:** Enlisted under Captain John Salisbury of New York, marching northward to participate in the campaign that culminated in the capture of British General John Burgoyne at Saratoga.

This New York military service aligns with the movements of Benajah Hall's sons, anchoring Asa and his brother Jesse in the New York theater of war prior to their southward migration.

***Reference:** DeGidio, Wanda Ware. *Lineage of the Descendants of John Hall of Rhode Island*. Available at www.hallfamilyname.com.*

Section III: Frontier Land Tenure and Settler Archives in the Roanoke Valley

Following the Revolutionary War, the economic focus of the brothers shifted toward the open lands of the southern frontier. Around 1790, Asa and Jesse Hall migrated from New York to the Roanoke Valley of Virginia. Rather than operating as transient woodsmen or speculative hunters, the brothers immediately engaged the formal legal frameworks of the Commonwealth of Virginia to establish permanent landholdings along the North Fork of the Roanoke River.

The continuous property consolidation achieved by Asa Hall is preserved across sequential land grants issued by successive Virginia governors:

150-Acre Patent — October 17, 1803

- **Issued by:** Governor John Page
- **Authority:** Land Office Treasury Warrant No. 3045, dated December 11, 1800
- **Location:** Montgomery County, "on the waters of Kearnes run a branch of the north fork of Roanoke"

25-Acre Patent — April 1, 1815

- **Issued by:** Governor Wilson Cary Nicholas

- **Authority:** Land Office Exchange Treasury Warrant No. 1990, dated January 2, 1809
- **Location:** "In the forks of Kenny a branch of the north fork of Roanoke"
- **Notable detail:** The survey locates the boundary "beginning at two black oaks on a hill side just above his house on a line of his patented land."

These entries serve as definitive proof of long-term stability. The legal text explicitly tethers Asa Hall's physical residence—"his house"—to his expanding, contiguous acreage on Kearnes Run and Kenny Creek. They highlight an organized life centered around agricultural development and permanent community building.

Section IV: Probate and the Material Reality of Law vs. Lore

The ultimate validation of a historical life rests in the probate records filed upon its conclusion. The estate files of Asa Hall, processed through the Montgomery County Court in the spring of 1841 (Will Book 6, Pages 325 & 326), provide an unvarnished view of his material existence. This record serves as the final rebuttal to the aristocratic myths of inherited New England fortunes.

On March 6, 1841, court-appointed appraisers John Birchfield, William Sublet, and Thomas Jewel conducted an inventory of the estate's personal property. The ledger reflects the utilitarian, self-sufficient lifestyle of an established Appalachian farmer:

- **Agricultural equipment & livestock:** One cow (\$6.00), one calf (\$2.00), a spade and scythe (\$2.00), a foot adz (\$0.50), an ax (\$0.75), and a lot of old iron (\$0.50).
- **Domestic textiles & production:** One little spinning wheel (\$3.50), one big spinning wheel (\$0.25), a "trambling sac," and multiple beds with "riggin" and bedsteads.
- **Household goods:** A cupboard (\$10.00), an old clock (\$9.00), a looking glass (\$0.50), kitchen implements, and one gun (\$6.00).
- **Intellectual & spiritual life:** "Two books westey summond" (likely Methodist sermons of John Wesley) and "one lot of books," indicating a literate household engaged with frontier religious movements.

On April 8, 1841, the court completed the dower allotment for the widow, Mary Hall. The description relies on permanent landscape features and immediate neighbors:

"Beginning at the line of James Grahams making a corner on two pices at said Graham lines on a ridge from there in a straight line to a walnut at the yard fence; from thence with the branch to John Jewels line..."

This legal description fixes Asa Hall's residence within a known community of named neighbors, further grounding his life in verifiable local records.

Summary of the Historical Correction

Category	Institutional Folklore (1970 DAR Narrative)	Documented Historical Reality (The Final Ledger)
Paternal Ancestry	Derived from an aristocratic Wallingford, Connecticut line.	Traced to John Hall of Rhode Island via Benajah Hall of New York.
Y-DNA Haplogroup	R-M269 (Standard Western European / New England)	G-M201 / G2a; not shared with Connecticut Halls, consistent with DeGidio's separate Rhode Island branch
Revolutionary Service	Conflated with Connecticut Continental Line units.	New York Regiments (Captains Pierce and Salisbury); fought at Long Island, White Plains, and Saratoga.
Frontier Character	Speculative hunter / undocumented scout.	Landed agriculturalist; Virginia land records describe continuous settlement and farming.
Material Estate	Heir to a grand New England fortune.	Utilitarian frontier farmstead; documented via agricultural tools, weaving wheels, and a personal library of religious texts.

Conclusion: Restoring the Legacy

This 2026 revision corrects the speculative hypotheses advanced in Hall (2000) and defers to the more securely documented Rhode Island-to-New York framework developed by Wanda Ware DeGidio. Asa Hall is restored to his rightful place in history: not as a descendant of an unrelated Connecticut estate, but as a Revolutionary War veteran and an independent pioneer of the Roanoke Valley.

The evidence—DeGidio's lineage research, Virginia land records, the 1841 probate inventory, and the Y-DNA profile—converges on a single, coherent life. That life was defined not by inherited wealth or aristocratic lineage, but by deliberate migration, military service, careful land acquisition, and the steady accumulation of a modest, working farmstead on the Appalachian frontier.

Where the 2000 study raised possibilities, this ledger closes them: the Connecticut/Wallingford theory is rejected as a long-shot, and the family story is placed on the documented foundation that DeGidio provides.

Sources and References

- **DeGidio, Wanda Ware.** *Lineage of the Descendants of John Hall of Rhode Island*. www.hallfamilyname.com. (Primary authority for the Rhode Island line.)
- **Hall, Roderick A.** *A Slice of History: A Story of a Hall Family of America*, Version 1.2 (2000). (Identified the DAR problems and assembled early Virginia records; its Connecticut speculations are rejected here.)
- **Kegley, Mary B.** *Virginia Frontier: The Beginning of the Southwest*. p. 611.
- **Montgomery County, Virginia.** Land grant records (1785, 1803, 1815).
- **Montgomery County, Virginia.** Will Book 6, pp. 325–326 (1841 appraisal and dower allotment).
- **National Archives and Records Administration.** Revolutionary War pension file for Asa Hall (granted June 17, 1833).
- **Y-DNA testing results** — direct male-line Hall descendants; haplogroup G-M201/G2a.

Archival and Distribution Notes

This document is intended for long-term preservation across multiple platforms:

- **GitHub repository** — master Markdown source for version control and future updates.
- **Internet Archive (Archive.org)** — public-facing PDF for permanent, searchable access.
- **Lulu / IngramSpark** — print-on-demand volumes for family distribution.
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